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CEO communication: engagement, longevity and founder centrality

An exploratory study in Italy

Francesca Conte, Alfonso Siano and Agostino Vollero
Department of Political, Social and Communication Sciences, University of Salerno, Fisciano, Italy

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to analyse the engagement of chief executive officers (CEOs) in corporate communication and focus on how their approach to communication develops in relation to the longevity of their tenure. The paper also explores how founder centrality is linked to the objectives of CEO communication and the CEOs' use of personal social media.

Design/methodology/approach – The paper brings together the relevant literature from different disciplines, related to leadership communication, CEO longevity and founder centrality, and reveals a number of unexplored issues. Four research questions were defined and an exploratory survey was carried out, involving 93 CEOs from large companies located in Italy.

Findings – The results show that CEOs are strongly engaged in institutional communication. Short-tenured CEOs seem more engaged in building and consolidating relationship networks with specific stakeholders (customers and employees), while long-tenured CEOs tend to be more involved in institutional and financial communications.

Research limitations/implications – Due to the exploratory research design and the circumscribed sample from a single country (Italy), further cross-national evidence is needed to substantiate the suggested links between engagement in communication activities and longevity. The study highlights the managerial and communication skills that CEOs must be provided with during their corporate tenure, thus suggesting the need to further examine the "life cycle" of CEO communication activities.

Originality/value – The paper sheds light on CEO communication dynamics. It is the first of its kind in the Italian context, where some factors, such as longevity of tenure, seem to play an important role in shaping corporate communication objectives and activities.

Keywords Corporate communications, CEO communication, CEO longevity, CEO personal social media, Founder centrality

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

This paper tackles the increasing importance of the chief executive officer (CEO) in the communication strategies of large companies. Several authors in the academic and business communities have emphasised the role of CEOs and have considered them as the main corporate communicator and the true symbol of corporate identity (Argenti *et al.*, 2005; van der Jagt, 2005; Gaines-Ross, 2008; Shugoll, 2012; Brønn, 2014; Zerfass *et al.*, 2014). CEOs have a strong influence on "the tone at the top" of companies (Craig and Amernic, 2011). In fact, decision making in communication relies on the activities of CEOs, who are heavily involved in the development and implementation of corporate communication strategies (Ferns *et al.*, 2008). According to the research from the Tuck School of Business, for the companies included in the index of Fortune 500, CEOs spend, on average, between 50 and 80 per cent of their time in business communication (Argenti, 2007). There are several examples of CEOs, such as Steve Jobs, Bill Gates, Richard Branson, who have managed effective relationships with a wide range of stakeholders, by the force of their personalities and communication.

Most research regarding the role and influence of CEOs on corporate communication has focussed on the international context (van der Jagt, 2005; Pollach and Kerbler, 2011), especially the USA and the UK (Murray and White, 2005). Conversely, to date no systematic



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efforts have analysed the Italian scenario (Kitchen and Laurence, 2003). This study thus specifically focusses on CEOs from large companies in Italy.

First, although the role of leaders in corporate communication has been widely debated (Hamrefors, 2010; Fairhurst and Connaughton, 2014), only a few empirical studies have analysed the communication activities which CEOs are most engaged in and those that are usually delegated to other organisational members or external consultants. In particular, the level of engagement of CEOs in corporate communication activities carried out with different stakeholders remains largely unexplored (Shugoll, 2012; Zerfass and Sherzada, 2015).

In order to investigate CEO communication activities in the Italian context, this study takes into account that Italian firms are usually family organisations in which CEOs often have a long tenure and are frequently the founders of the firm. Despite some studies on these two issues (Kelly *et al.*, 2000; Song, 2006), the analysis of the influence of CEO longevity and founder centrality on the activities and objectives of corporate communication has scarcely been explored in the communication literature.

Lastly, effective communication by CEOs requires the appropriate use of communication tools (Pincus *et al.*, 1991; Argenti *et al.*, 2005). The spread of digital tools has increasingly affected corporate leaders. Some studies have been carried out in the international context by communication consulting firms (*PRWeek*/Burson-Marsteller, 2008; Weber Shandwick, 2013, 2014), emphasising that digital media, especially personal social media, represent a good opportunity for increasing a CEO's visibility.

The paper is organised as follows. The review of the literature provides the theoretical background for the main constructs analysed (CEO and leadership communication, CEO longevity, founder centrality and CEO online communication) and fully delineates the four research questions that are then analysed through an exploratory survey on the CEOs of large companies located in Italy. Finally, the paper presents the findings and discussion, highlighting the managerial implications and insights for future research.

Conceptual background

CEO and leadership communication

The importance of leadership communication has been discussed in a number of studies which highlight its role in building alignment with stakeholders, executing strategy and achieving superior corporate performance (Hamrefors, 2010; Fairhurst, 2011). Two main theoretical paradigms emerge: one focusses on the transmission of information, and the other is meaning centred (Fairhurst and Connaughton, 2014).

The first perspective defines leadership communication as the: "controlled, purposeful transfer of meaning by which leaders influence a single person, a group, an organisation, or a community" (Barrett, 2006, p. 398). Studies adopting a transmissional view of communication often conceive communication as an essential factor to organisational functioning and a behavioural outcome (Burke *et al.*, 2007). A meaning-centred view of communication puts emphasis on the sense-making leadership and the formative power of language for communicative purposes (Shotter, 1993; Dougherty *et al.*, 2009).

A transmissional view of communication seems to be optimal "when the researcher's goal is to understand leadership communication amidst other relational and cognitive dynamics" (Fairhurst and Connaughton, 2014, p. 10). CEO communication is part of the larger context of leadership communication and the literature has focussed on how CEOs contribute to creating the corporate culture, setting the tone of communication, defining and spreading the corporate vision, thus resonating with the expectations of different stakeholders (Gaines-Ross, 2000; Kitchen and Laurence, 2003; Amernic and Craig, 2006). We therefore adopted a transmissional approach in which leadership occurs through a process of interaction, and leadership communication is aimed at influencing and aligning stakeholders by defining a corporate vision (Westley and Mintzberg, 1989; Shipman *et al.*, 2010).

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Among different stakeholders, employee relations represent a major challenge for company's success (Arthur W. Page Society, 2013). CEOs have particular responsibilities, in fact, for communicating a shared vision primarily within the internal context of the organisation, by establishing an ethical climate and moral tone, and providing a sense of purpose and direction (Shockley-Zalabak, 2011). Pincus *et al.* (1991) identify four principles that CEOs need to observe in employee communication: consistency of messages with corporate objectives; compassion, i.e. showing an understanding of employees' needs; selectivity, i.e. differentiation of communication activities carried out by CEOs from those implemented by managers; and integration of CEO communication within the corporate communication plan.

The dyadic relationship between CEOs and employees is supported in the literature which highlights the importance of communication in constituting leadership interactions and processes. Yukl (2012) categorises effective leadership behaviours, including clarifying, problem solving, supporting and networking. In line with this perspective, Johansson *et al.* (2014) consider four prominent leader communication behaviour categories: initiating structure, facilitating work, relational dynamics and representing the unit.

These leader behaviours cover the main aspects of communication behaviour both inside and outside the organisation (Johansson *et al.*, 2014). In fact, to achieve strategic objectives, CEOs and corporate leaders engage employees in a dialogue and establish long-term relations with external corporate stakeholders (Zerfass *et al.*, 2014). Thus, strategic leadership communication requires an integrated approach which involves different communication functions related to specific objectives and channels: employee communications for internal consensus building; financial communications aimed at ensuring transparency in investor relations; community communications for image building; government communications aimed at meeting social expectations; and marketing communications for sales (Argenti *et al.*, 2005). In order to ensure an effective leadership communication, these functions need to be aligned with and support the corporate strategy.

Communication activities with stakeholders and the ethical behaviour adopted by CEOs significantly affect the perception of the organisation by the public (Ind, 1990; Gray and Balmer, 1998; Watson, 2007). In fact, van der Jagt (2005) points out how strongly the field of corporate communication and reputation management is connected to the leadership role. In the twenty-first century, CEOs recognise that reputation is much more complex than an advertising campaign. Thus, CEOs become actively involved in many aspects of corporate communication: they decide strategic communication objectives, approve communication plans and participate in brainstorming ideas, executive conferences and university forums, etc. (Gaines-Ross, 2008). In addition, CEOs are ultimately responsible for corporate sustainability communication (Sims and Brinkmann, 2002; De Wolf *et al.*, 2012). The ethics and responsible leadership literature identifies three general forms of communication-based leader responsibilities, including "communicating appropriate values"; "maintaining adequate communication to be informed of organisational operations" and "maintaining openness to signs of problems" (Seeger and Ulmer, 2003, p. 63).

Despite the growing focus on the issue of CEO communication, there are few empirical studies that specifically analyse the level of engagement of CEOs in communication activities with different stakeholders. Thus, the first research question of this study is the following:

RQ1. What communication activities are CEOs most engaged in? What communication activities do they tend to delegate?

CEO longevity

The different levels of CEO engagement in communication activities can be affected by a multiplicity of factors, some of which seem context specific (Kitchen and Laurence, 2003). In fact,

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the significant presence of family businesses in Italy (Corbetta, 2010; AIDAF *et al.*, 2014)[1], frequently characterised by long-tenured CEOs, can impact on the communication behaviour of CEOs.

In terms of CEO turnover, tenure is the total number of years in which CEOs have been in office from the time they assumed this role in an organisation; long-tenured CEOs are expected to stay for more than six years (Weisbach, 1988; Song, 2006). As for CEO longevity, some research in the financial literature equates long tenure with managerial entrenchment (Ryan and Wiggins, 2004). Some authors believe that a longer tenure reflects a greater sense of belonging to the organisation; others argue that it demonstrates a continuity of leadership, thus facilitating the improvement of business performance (Song, 2006).

According to Hermalin and Weisbach (1998), CEOs who have a higher perceived ability than potential successors, are able to maintain their position for a long time, and have more contractual power with respect to the dominant coalition, that is the group of people in charge of the governance of complex organisations, which are not necessarily formalised (Bowen, 2009; Johansson and Ottestig, 2011). In fact, the philosophical alignment or synergic agreement between the board and CEOs should be considered as a determinant of the length of CEO tenure (Song, 2006).

Several studies have examined the relationship between CEO tenure and company performance (Wulf *et al.*, 2010; Huang, 2013), showing that long-tenured CEOs lead to a higher overall firm performance. Corporate performance is more effective when CEOs have a high level of agreement and a positive consensus with the board (Brickley, 2003). In this context, studies normally find the optimal CEO tenure to be between nine and 14 years (Shen and Cannella, 2002). Thus, communication flows activated by CEOs are important, as they help to create and maintain empathic relationships with members of top management and stakeholders. Therefore, our second research question is:

RQ2. Do CEO communication activities vary in relation to CEO longevity?

Founder centrality

In Italy, the role of CEO or president often coincides with that of founder (Handler, 1989; Ibrahim, 1992). In the literature on corporate management, the status of founder has often been used as an indicator of the power of an executive (Adams *et al.*, 2005). Finkelstein (1992) identifies four different sources of executive power: structural (positional), owned, trained and prestige. When CEOs are also corporate founders, they hold two distinct sources of formal power: the positional power (because CEOs are present in top management) and the power of proprietorship (due to their status as founder). Consequently, CEO founders have more formal power than non-founder CEOs.

CEO founders have a significant influence on the strategic management of the family organisation, in particular on two aspects that are closely related to corporate communication: corporate identity and corporate personality. The founders contribute to the definition of corporate identity by influencing top management decisions and, specifically, communication objectives with their own personal and professional backgrounds, behaviours, distinctive values and personalities (Olins, 1978; Balmer, 2001; Melewar and Karaosmanoglu, 2006).

Frequently, personal history and the experiences of the founder are actively addressed and kept alive through communication campaigns, aimed at creating a distinctive brand heritage and to improve the corporate image (Ind, 1990). In this sense, the close links between the corporate identity and personality of the founders represent a significant opportunity for brand building and for developing an effective communication strategy. In fact, the personal values of the founders, disseminated to stakeholders, progressively

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become the key aspects of corporate communication and remain a long time after their death (Kelly *et al.*, 2000, Melewar and Karaosmanoglu, 2006).

Regarding corporate personality, Olins (1978) argues that organisations mirror the personality of their founder, who lays the ground for the distinctive objectives and tone of the company's communication. The founder exerts a strong influence on the creation, dissemination and sharing of corporate vision (Balmer, 2001). The corporate culture of a family business is related to the attitudes, skills and beliefs of the founders (Harvey and Evans, 1994). These aspects, emphasised in leadership communication, are crucial to establishing relationships of trust with stakeholders (Burke *et al.*, 2007; Mazzei, 2010) and to building the reputation of the CEO and top managers (Kitchen and Laurence, 2003). Thus, one of the main objectives of leadership communication is also reputation management in corporate crises, in which the CEO assumes the role of main spokesperson (Watson, 2007).

Although the role of CEO founders in the context of family businesses has been explored, few studies have investigated the interconnection between this role and the pursued objectives of corporate communication, especially in the Italian context. Thus, the third research question is:

RQ3. Is there a link between being a corporate founder and the objectives of CEO communication?

CEO communication online: personal social media

CEO communication with different stakeholders has been modified by online communication tools (Weber Shandwick and KRC, 2013; Ngai and Singh, 2014). Online communication involves the use both of corporate websites and social media directly initiated and controlled by CEOs (e.g. CEO blog, CEO social network). These tools can be defined as owned personal media, according to the three media categories of owned, paid and earned (Corcoran, 2009; Hanna *et al.*, 2011).

There are many benefits for CEOs of exploiting social media (Weber Shandwick and KRC, 2013): facilitation in information sharing, positive impact on corporate reputation and on the perception of corporate innovation. Digital media also offer CEOs opportunities for developing a strategy of self-promotion and personal branding (Dutta, 2010).

Although CEOs recognise the great potential of social media (Arthur W. Page Society, 2013) and are gradually embracing the opportunities that come from digital tools (Weber Shandwick, 2014), few CEOs have blogs, and the use of social networks (such as LinkedIn, Twitter and Facebook) is still limited (*PRWeek*/Burson-Marsteller, 2008; Weber Shandwick, 2012, 2013). However, there has been a slight increase in the publication of videos on YouTube and LinkedIn has become the most popular social network for top executives (Weber Shandwick, 2014).

CEO communications in the digital environment include the launch of new products, changes adopted in leadership and business strategy, reporting financial results, describing philanthropic activities, as well as personal news relating to a CEO's career. Content regarding customer relations can be found in about one-third of the analysed CEO blogs, thus highlighting how these communication channels progressively tend to adopt a customer-relationship focus (Esteves and Bohorquez, 2008).

Considering the international scenario, whereas CEO social profiles of North American companies show CEOs as active participants in social, political and public life, European CEOs are primarily business focused (Pollach and Kerbler, 2011). In both cases, personal social media could increase CEO visibility enabling them to directly express their ideas and vision. Therefore, the fourth research question is:

RQ4. Which personal social media are most adopted by CEOs?

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Research design and methodology

Given the particular research questions and difficulty in reaching selected respondents (CEOs of large companies), we exploited an exploratory approach through a structured questionnaire. An exploratory research design including a survey is a common approach in social sciences (Sarantakos, 2005). Surveys can also provide preliminary interconnections between the constructs analysed which have not been specified in extant literature (Bryman, 2012), thus being appropriate to our theoretical goals.

Measures

Due to the absence of previous measurement instruments for the constructs we aim to explore, we created the survey by generating questions and items from the extant literature (in Table I, we detail the specific references used). The item generation approach was therefore deductive. This procedure ensures an adequate representation of the domains of interest within a construct (Hinkin, 1998; Jian *et al.*, 2014). In the design of the measurement instrument, we adopt a "leader's self-report", one of the three possible strategies mentioned in the work of Jian *et al.* (2014), because our interest was closely related to the CEOs' perceptions of their role in corporate communication. This approach, in conjunction with the survey method, is in fact useful for studies that support a transmissional view of communication (Fairhurst and Connaughton, 2014) and is quite common in research on CEO communication (e.g. Kitchen and Laurence, 2003) (Table I).

Due to the need for brevity and ensuring the anonymity of respondents, we did not include individual background factors (e.g. age) in the questionnaire that could potentially affect communication activities.

Sample

The unit of analysis included CEOs from companies located in Italy, which were considered in the Mediobanca 2013 report on the "Principal Italian companies" in the industry and services sectors. This report contains 1,497 companies who achieved an annual turnover of at least 50 million euros in 2013.

Company representatives from the branches of the group and business-to-business companies (665) were excluded from the analysis due to their limited corporate awareness of the general public and the limited flows of communication activated by their CEOs. The same criteria were adopted by the main rankings of corporate reputation, such as RepTrak Pulse of Reputation Institute.

Research questions	Survey questions	No. of items	References
RQ1. What communication activities are CEOs most engaged in? What communication activities do they tend to delegate? *RQ2*. Do CEO communication activities vary in relation to CEO longevity?	Type of communication activities in which CEOs are most engaged	10	Pincus *et al.* (1991), Argenti *et al.* (2005), Gaines-Ross (2008), Yukl (2012)
RQ3. Is there a link between being a corporate founder and the objectives of CEO communication?	Type of objectives of CEO communication	6	Ind (1990), Balmer (2001), Kitchen and Laurence (2003), Melewar and Karaosmanoglu (2006), Watson (2007), Burke *et al.* (2007)
RQ4. Which personal social media are most adopted by CEOs?	Type of personal social media adopted by CEOs	7	*PRWeek*/Burson-Marsteller (2008), Weber Shandwick (2010, 2012, 2013)

Table I.
Research questions, survey questions, number of items and references

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The resulting population consisted of 832 Italian companies who achieved an annual turnover of at least 50 million euros. The study extracted a random sample of 349 companies (4 per cent confidence interval) from the population.

CEOs were contacted mainly through an e-mail with the link to the online platform where they could complete the questionnaire. The personal contacts of CEOs were collected through a search of corporate websites, the platform "Comunicazione Italiana", personal social networks (LinkedIn, Facebook, Twitter) and by phone calls and e-mails to business managers (general manager, chief marketing officer, chief communications officer, chief financial officer). The research was conducted from May to October 2013.

A total of 93 CEOs responded to the survey corresponding to a 26.7 per cent response rate which is in line with other studies investigating similar populations (top managers or representatives of the organisations) (Baruch, 1999; Waldman *et al.*, 2006). Data were analysed using SPSS version 23. To test whether the 93 respondent CEOs were representative of the population of 832 companies in the Mediobanca report, we compared the distribution of different industries between the population and respondents, and found no significant differences between the two.

Findings

Respondent profiles

Most of the respondent CEOs (75 out of 93) are not founders of the company where they currently worked. The majority of respondents (91.4 per cent) have held the position in the company for more than two years: in particular, 37.6 per cent "from two to six years", 32.3 per cent "from six to ten years" and 21.5 per cent "for more than ten years". Only eight respondents of the sample have been a CEO of the organisation for "less than a year". In summary, the respondents have a good knowledge of the business environment in which they play a leadership role. A total of 46.2 per cent are short-tenured CEOs, i.e. who have been in this role from one to six years; and 53.8 per cent are long-tenured CEOs, i.e. six or more years.

The companies in which the CEOs operated belong to different industries, especially "tertiary/services" (20.4 per cent), "food" (18.3 per cent) and "clothing" (14 per cent) sectors. Demographic results and backgrounds of respondents are detailed in Table II.

CEO engagement and activities in corporate communication

The CEOs in our survey do not usually delegate communications activities, especially those of a strategic value (see Table III). In particular, the central role of CEOs is in "making decisions about strategic communication objectives" ("actively engaged" 63.4 per cent – mean value 1.37): which was the only activity "not delegated to third parties". The other activities in which CEOs affirmed to be more actively engaged are "spreading the mission and vision of the organisation" (mean 1.22), "approving the communication plan" (1.45) and "act as the face and spokesperson (institutional communication)" (1.47). CEOs of the sample thus seem to focus particularly on typical activities of corporate communication.

Conversely, communication activities that were mostly delegated to third parties related to media relations ("managing relationships with the media" – mean 2.01) and government-community relations ("building a dialogue with the PA actors and the community" – mean 1.96).

By accumulating scores assigned to these individual indicators, a composite index was developed, thus representing a more general dimension of the degree of CEO engagement in communication. We used the procedure indicated in the work of Babbie (2012), in order to ensure that all selected items had a logical validity and provided an adequate amount of variance (p. 167). As for the range of the index score, we chose to reflect the three response categories of "original" indicators. We thus obtained both an appropriate range of

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		n	%
CEO founder			
Yes		18	19.4
No		75	80.6
Years of CEO tenure			
Less than a year	Short-tenured CEOs (up to six years)	8	8.6
From two to six years		35	37.6
From six to ten years	Long-tenured CEOs (over six years)	30	32.3
For more than ten years		20	21.5
Industries			
Tertiary/services		19	20.4
Food and beverage		17	18.3
Textile		13	14.0
Electronics		10	10.8
Automobiles and components		9	9.7
Bank/insurance		7	7.5
Telecommunication services		7	7.5
Transportation		7	7.5
Chemical and pharmaceuticals		4	4.3

Table II.
Respondent profiles

Note: $n = 93$

CEO communication activities	*n*	Mean value	SD	SE mean
Mission and vision	93	1.22	0.486	0.050
Decide strategic communication objectives	93	1.37	0.484	0.050
Approve communication plan	93	1.45	0.599	0.062
Institutional communication	93	1.47	0.669	0.069
Employee relations	93	1.56	0.729	0.076
Corporate sustainability communication	93	1.76	0.743	0.077
Investor relations	93	1.77	0.861	0.089
Customer relations	93	1.82	0.751	0.078
Government and community relations	93	1.96	0.779	0.081
Media relations	93	2.01	0.759	0.079

Table III.
Mean values (1 = actively engaged – 3 = activities delegated to third parties), standard deviation and standard error mean for CEO communication activities

measurement in the index and a sufficient number of cases at each point (Babbie, 2012). The three points of this index thus correspond to three types of CEOs:

(1) "proactive CEOs" in corporate communication; almost half of respondents fell into this category (about 44 per cent; $n = 41$);

(2) "moderate CEOs", where the approach to communication management was weighted and thoughtful (43 per cent; $n = 40$); and

(3) "delegating CEOs", who tended to outsource almost all communication activities (13 per cent; $n = 12$).

CEO communication activities and CEO longevity

To explore if CEO longevity is linked to different type of CEO communication activities, we compare the mean values of communication activities of two groups of CEOs (short- and long-tenured CEOs) and test for actual differences (Tables IV and V).

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Media relations	Employee relations	Investor relations	Government relations	Customer relations	Mission and vision	Institutional communication	Approve comm. plan	Sustainability communication	Decide strategic communication objectives
					Mean value (SD)				
< 5 years (n = 43)									
1.98 (0.831)	1.40 (0.660)	1.98 (0.913)	1.91 (0.811)	1.65 (0.783)	1.16 (0.374)	1.63 (0.691)	1.51 (0.551)	1.84 (0.754)	1.37 (0.489)
> 6 years (n = 50)									
2.04 (0.699)	1.70 (0.763)	1.60 (0.782)	2.00 (0.756)	1.96 (0.699)	1.26 (0.565)	1.34 (0.626)	1.40 (0.639)	1.70 (0.735)	1.36 (0.485)
Total (n = 93)									
2.01 (0.759)	1.56 (0.729)	1.77 (0.861)	1.96 (0.779)	1.82 (0.751)	1.22 (0.486)	1.47 (0.669)	1.45 (0.599)	1.76 (0.743)	1.37 (0.484)

Table IV.
Different CEO communication activities – mean values and standard deviation according to CEO longevity

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	Levene's test for equality of variances		*t*-test for equality of means		
	F	Sig.	*t*	df	Sig. (2-tailed)
Media relations					
Equal variances assumed	3.414	0.068	−0.399	91	0.691
Equal variances not assumed			−0.394	82.486	0.695
Employee relations					
Equal variances assumed	2.742	0.101	−2.043	91	*0.044*
Equal variances not assumed			−2.066	90.995	0.042
Investor relations					
Equal variances assumed	2.598	0.110	2.144	91	*0.035*
Equal variances not assumed			2.119	83.342	0.037
Government and community relations					
Equal variances assumed	1.366	0.246	−0.572	91	0.569
Equal variances not assumed			−0.569	86.713	0.571
Customer relations					
Equal variances assumed	5.010	*0.028*	−2.010	91	0.047
Equal variances not assumed			−1.992	85.022	*0.050*
Mission and vision					
Equal variances assumed	4.492	0.037	−0.962	91	0.339
Equal variances not assumed			−0.991	85.679	0.324
Institutional communication					
Equal variances assumed	2.445	0.121	2.107	91	*0.038*
Equal variances not assumed			2.092	85.668	0.039
Approve communication plan					
Equal variances assumed	0.143	0.706	0.895	91	0.373
Equal variances not assumed			0.905	90.998	0.368
Corporate sustainability communication					
Equal variances assumed	0.071	0.790	0.887	91	0.378
Equal variances not assumed			0.885	88.231	0.378
Decide strategic communication objectives					
Equal variances assumed	0.057	0.812	0.119	91	0.905
Equal variances not assumed			0.119	88.694	0.905

Table V. Different communication activities – *t*-test according to CEO longevity

In Table V, we present the results of the statistical tests that allow the determining of there being significant differences or not (p-values $\leqslant 0.05$ are in italics)[2].

Four out of ten communication activities present significant differences between the two groups, specifically "to strengthen the employees' sense of belonging to the organisation", "provide investors with accurate news about corporate performance", "creating stable relationships with customers" and "act as the face and spokesperson (institutional communication)".

The results show that short-tenured CEOs are more engaged in activities related to employees and consumers compared to long-tenured CEOs; the latter are more interested to embody the role of corporate communicators (institutional communication) and in communication activities directed at corporate investors.

Objectives of CEO communication and founder centrality

The survey highlights the main objectives of CEO communications: "improve corporate image" (62.9 per cent of total respondents) and "disseminate the core corporate values to

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stakeholders" (57.1 per cent). Most respondents affirmed that CEO communication is aimed at "establishing long relationships with stakeholders based on trust" (48.6 per cent) and "involving them in a shared corporate vision" (44.3 per cent). CEO communication activities also played an effective role, albeit to a lesser extent, in managing crisis situations (28.6 per cent) and in strengthening the reputation of top management (27.1 per cent).

Observing the differences in responses, we also investigate if CEO founders tend to exploit communication for reputational purposes ("establish long relationships with stakeholders based on trust"), more than CEO non-founders, who seem to adopt an image approach to communication (over two-thirds indicate it as a primary objective).

In both cases (see Table VI), differences are not statistically significant. Hence, there is no sufficient evidence to support the assumption that CEO founders and not founders have different types of communication objectives.

Use of personal social media

CEOs are found to be still reluctant to adopt personal social media: almost 50 per cent of respondents did not use these communication tools (see Table VII). The use of LinkedIn (28.1 per cent), Twitter (21.9 per cent) and Facebook (12.5 per cent) was limited.

A comparison of these results with the global use of social media is interesting. In fact, Duggan *et al.* (2015) found that Facebook was the most popular social media (71 per cent of online adults). Conversely, findings related to other platforms, such as LinkedIn (28 per cent) and Twitter (23 per cent), are in line with the CEOs' use of personal social media.

We also analyse the use of personal social media according to the different types of CEOs (proactive, moderate and delegating) previously identified. One-way ANOVA was used to

Objectives of CEO communication	CEO founder/ not founder	*n*	Mean value	*t*-test for equality of means Sig. (2-tailed)
Disseminate core corporate values among stakeholders	Founder	18	0.39	0.698
	Not founder	75	0.44	
Involve stakeholders in a shared corporate vision	Founder	18	0.33	1.000
	Not founder	75	0.33	
Strengthen the role and reputation of top management	Founder	18	0.28	0.395
	Not founder	75	0.19	
Establish long relationships with stakeholders based on trust	Founder	18	0.50	0.191
	Not founder	75	0.33	
Improve corporate image	Founder	18	0.28	0.066
	Not founder	75	0.52	
Encourage better management of crisis situations	Founder	18	0.17	0.583
	Not founder	75	0.23	

Table VI. Objectives of CEO communication and founder centrality

Personal social media	% of cases	*n*
LinkedIn	28.1	18
Twitter	21.9	14
Facebook	12.5	8
Blogs	7.8	5
YouTube	6.3	4
Google+	1.6	1
Pinterest	1.6	1
None	48.4	31

Table VII. CEO use of personal social media

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determine whether there are significant differences among the three groups. The result is not statistically significant (Table VIII).

By analysing the personal social media use considering two groups ("delegating CEOs" and "proactive CEOs"), instead, the result of *t*-test is significant (see Table IX).

This means that these two CEO groups significantly differ in using personal social media, being proactive CEOs in corporate communication more likely to use personal social media than delegating CEOs.

Lastly, as for the main rationale behind the adoption of personal social media, the few CEOs that use them, claimed to especially convey institutional news of the company in which they operated and messages regarding opinions/personal situations.

Discussion

Considering its exploratory nature, the paper has provided new insights into understanding the role of CEOs as communicators in the Italian context.

Regarding *RQ1*, the study suggests that CEOs are more likely to act as the corporate face and spokesperson, and to engage in communication concerning the dissemination and sharing of institutional values and corporate vision. The findings also highlight the central role of CEOs especially in communication activities of strategic value that CEOs tend to not delegate to communication managers. This is in line with the work of Brønn (2014) showing that the communication staff is not involved in decision making about strategic communication and the support of CEO is critical in communication managers' acceptance on the top management team. Thus, CEOs' perceptions shed light on the institutionalisation of strategic communication as a process where it becomes an "integral and self evident part of the strategic management of an organization" (Tench *et al.*, 2009, p. 151).

These results also suggest that CEOs' behaviour underpins some distinctive features of leadership communication, i.e. the alignment with key stakeholders and the energetic communication of a vision (Ferns *et al.*, 2008; Zerfass and Sherzada, 2015). A cautionary note should be added on this point. The emphasis on sharing a "strong" vision, typical of charismatic leadership, could also lead to narcissistic leaders and "corporate cultism" (Tourish and Vatcha, 2005; Craig and Amernic, 2011). This type of leader can be a poor listener, lacking support and empathy, and often tending to overstate their claims (Conger, 1990; Tourish and Vatcha, 2005).

The findings concerning *RQ2* show a possible link between CEO longevity and some CEO communication activities. The research underlines that the surveyed CEOs, in the early

Table VIII.
Use of personal social media – one-way ANOVA analysis considering three types of CEOs

	Sum of squares	df	Mean square	*F*	Sig.
Between groups	10.111	2	5.055	1.334	0.071
Within groups	111.639	61	1.830		
Total	121.750	63			

Table IX.
Use of personal social media – *t*-test considering "proactive" and "delegating" CEOs

	Levene's test for equality of variances		*t*-test for equality of means		
	F	Sig.	*t*	df	Sig. (2-tailed)
Personal social media use ("proactive" and "delegating" CEOs)					
Equal variances assumed	0.465	0.500	2.187	36	0.035
Equal variances not assumed			2.547	17.725	0.020

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years of their corporate activities, seek to create and consolidate the network of relationships with the key stakeholders (employees and consumers) through effective communication. CEO communication thus aims first to consolidate a sense of belonging to the organisation in order to foster trust relationships (Pincus *et al.*, 1991; Mazzei, 2010). Our findings support the view that spreading a company's vision begins by sharing this vision within the company and that the CEOs role is central in terms of developing the alignment of employees towards a common goal (Mazzei, 2010), above all in the early years of their tenure. At a later stage, the CEOs reported that they engage more in institutional communication, thus acting as the corporate spokesperson, and in investor relations. This resonates with the work of Walters *et al.* (2007) that show that the relationship between CEO tenure and returns to shareholders is positive where CEO tenure increases. Long-tenured CEOs seem therefore more likely to have acquired the right knowledge, experiences and skills to successfully manage investor relations, thus having also positive effects on business performance.

The findings reveal that different types of communication objectives are not affected by founder centrality (*RQ3*). Thus, it is no possible to draw differences between CEO founders and not founders, in terms of reputation or image approach to communication.

Lastly, the study identifies three CEO profiles from Italian large companies in terms of engagement in communication activities ("proactive", "moderate" and "delegating" CEOs). The findings show a considerable CEO engagement in corporate communication, as most of the surveyed CEOs were proactive. Despite the fact that Italian CEOs are still reluctant to adopt personal social media (*RQ4*), "proactive" CEOs are however the most likely to create and manage their own social media. In fact, CEOs who demonstrate a greater engagement in corporate communication activities are also the most active in the digital environment through the use of personal social media.

Theoretical and managerial implications

The above-mentioned three types of CEOs have a potential value in contributing to the debate on CEO communication. From a theoretical perspective, these categories could be connected with communication leadership styles identified by Blake and Mouton (1968) in the managerial grid, considering the dimension of people orientation, namely interpersonal relation.

Proactive CEOs seem to have some features of "team management", in which leaders feel that empowerment, commitment and trust are the key elements in creating a team atmosphere which result in high stakeholder satisfaction. This style is in line also with the participative leadership (House, 1996), in which leaders constantly interact with stakeholders, solicit their suggestions and take these recommendations into consideration before making a decision. Moderating CEOs could have the same attitudes of "middle-of-the-road", in which leaders try to achieve adequate goals in terms of interpersonal relations. At last, delegating CEOs seem to be associated with the style related to "impoverished management – Laissez faire", where leaders exercise minimum effort in motivating team environment, tend to assign responsibilities to others and leave followers to complete tasks on their own. This style also has similarities with delegating leadership (Hersey and Blanchard, 1982), characterised by low-relationship style, where the leader allows others to take responsibility for task decisions.

The study also offers practical implications for CEO communication. The findings show that some CEO communication activities can develop in relation to CEO longevity, thus suggesting different managerial and communication skills needed by CEOs during their tenure. In a first stage of their tenure (up to six years), CEOs should focus on building and maintaining strong relationships with employees and consumers. Thus, the skills needed are not only professional and interpersonal, but also motivational skills to strengthen a sense of belonging of employees to the organisation and build confidence in corporate

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leadership. Also listening skills are relevant in order to meet consumers' needs, welcome suggestions and deal with criticism. Long-tenured CEOs instead have the onus of spreading the long-term corporate vision with appropriate strategies. CEOs should be proactive, intuitive, able to influence others and to arouse positive feelings towards the organisation, and especially be able create a common path, generating involvement, participation and sharing. Moreover, in order to interact with shareholders, long-tenured CEOs should have analytical acumen, strategic flexibility, and familiarity with financial tools.

Lastly, the research provides a mapping of the different personal social media adopted by CEOs. An effective use of social media seems, in fact, to be closely related to leadership behaviours (Jiang *et al.*, 2016) and to a participative leadership style (proactive CEOs in our study), by which the power distance has been reduced, allowing CEOs to communicate with stakeholders in a friendly, authentic and informal manner. CEOs should thus be encouraged to be open-minded, embrace changes, and build a prominent and visible social media presence.

Limitations and future research

This paper represents a first contribution to analysing the several features of CEO communication that have not yet been fully investigated, especially in the Italian context. The main limitations of this study include the circumscribed sample (due to the difficulty in surveying CEOs directly) and the lack of various background variables that are needed to substantiate the suggested links between engagement in communication activities and longevity. In addition, it is necessary to point out that our study is focussed on the Italian context, characterised by some peculiarities, such as the specialisation in traditional manufacturing industries, the prevalence of family businesses and the presence of long-tenured family member's CEOs. An extension of this study to other countries is thus required to determine if the same pattern holds true in different places.

Due to its exploratory design, the study paves the way for future studies – both quantitative (e.g. with a longitudinal design) or/and qualitative (e.g. in-depth interviews to CEOs). In both cases, cross-national and cross-sector comparisons would improve our understanding of CEO communication in diverse geographical settings. In addition, further studies should consider different perspectives in designing measurement instruments (stakeholder view, third-party observations) both for a fuller understanding of CEO communication and to reduce the common method bias deriving from a leader's self-reporting perspective.

However, these limitations suggest a number of future avenues of research, at both theoretical and practical levels. First, it would be interesting to identify a life cycle of CEO communication activities in relation to CEO tenure. This might resonate with a "process of institutionalization of CEO tenure", as described both in the "leader life cycle theory" (Hambrick and Fukutomi, 1991) and "institutional theory" (Pfeffer, 1981). Hambrick and Fukutomi (1991) stated that during their tenure in office, CEOs go through a life cycle consisting of several seasons. When entering the new position, CEOs generally respond to the mandate, meeting the expectations of stakeholders and building legitimacy through constant relationships. Later, CEOs try to establish the tone for their tenure, selecting a specific vision and adopting a belief system which guides organisations. In a similar way, Pfeffer (1981) assumes that the institutionalisation of power of CEOs increases over their tenure. Thus, it would be interesting to investigate whether different skills and levels of engagement in specific communication activities are desirable in relation to various phases of this cycle, which might thus have significant impact both for theory and practice in leadership communication.

Equally interesting would be the analysis of CEO competencies and skills in relation to different communication activities. This could lead to insights regarding professional training courses both inside organisations and in business schools. Another opportunity of research

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could come from an in-depth analysis of the role of CEO founders, taking into account other categories of CEOs (successor CEOs, such as CEOs of second and third generation), beyond the dichotomous distinction presented in this study. In the same vein, it would be interesting to analyse the potential contribution of the "socioeconomic wealth" – a unique feature of family firms (Berrone *et al.*, 2012; Gottardo and Moisello, 2015) – in affecting the corporate communication decisions made by the top management. Socioeconomic wealth might help, in fact, to explain if any difference between the CEO founders (or members of the founder's family) and non-founders will be found in future research.

The preliminary results on social media used by Italian CEOs also pave the way for further investigation. Future research could investigate how the use of different communication tools adopted by CEOs, particularly digital personal media, could affect the development of relationships with various stakeholders, their leadership style and the creation of a symbiotic relationship with the company during their tenure.

Until we truly understand how CEOs concurrently communicate with their stakeholders and evolve in their position, and how their engagement in activities and tools relates overall to leadership communication, it will be difficult to determine the value of their initiatives as a corporate communication opportunity.

Notes

1. In Italy, family businesses correspond to over 85 per cent of the total organisations. In total, 66 per cent of Italian family businesses have members of the family on the management board. In the segment of mid-sized and large organisations (turnover > €50 million), family businesses are approximately 4,000 and involve approximately three million employees. Family businesses represent approximately almost 60 per cent of the Italian stock market (out of a total of about 290 listed companies), and account for over 25 per cent of its capitalisation (AIDAF, 2014).
2. As for "customer relations", we cannot assume homogeneity of variances (i.e. Levene's test results significant), thus we have to consider an approximate *t*-statistic (Welch *t*-test statistic – indicated in the second row in Table V) in which equal variances are not assumed.

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Corresponding author
Francesca Conte can be contacted at: fconte@unisa.it

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